



win his first world title, nine years after his last medal at a global event.

Klaus is quick to downplay his role. "I think we really overestimate the contribution of a coach! I can only guess why he wanted to work with me. He wasn't performing badly — he's been consistently over 85 metres, and he's thrown 90 as well. I think he was a little under the radar after 2021 despite those big throws. What I actually did was get him to train a little less. I wanted him to throw less and think more about what he needed to do as a javelin thrower," he says.

While Klaus expected Walcott to produce some big throws in Tokyo, he hadn't imagined gold. "I wasn't expecting that he would win gold. Of course not. I thought maybe he'd throw 86 or 87m in the best case, but

I guess it's not very far from 87 to 88. I was expecting a good result, but I also know anything can happen. Still, it came as a surprise when he won," he says.

In a World Championships full of surprises, the javelin final was no exception. Walcott became one of the oldest to win the title. World leader Julian Weber failed to make the podium, America's relatively unknown Curtis Thompson did, and Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem finished 10th.

From an Indian perspective, there was both disappointment and promise. Defending champion Neeraj finished eighth — his first time outside the top two at a major event since 2018 — but the emergence of 25-year-old Sachin Yadav, who came within 40 centimetres of a podium

Guiding hand, golden arm: Klaus Bartonietz with Neeraj Chopra during a training session that shaped India's Olympic dream. K. R. DEEPAK

finish on debut, offered reason for optimism.

Klaus has high praise for Sachin. "I wouldn't have been surprised if Sachin had won a medal. Half a metre more and he would have been on the podium. He was already over 86 metres and at that distance, 40 centimetres is nothing," he says.

At 6'5" and nearly 110 kilograms, Sachin combines size and strength with technique, says Klaus. "He's very tall. That's a great benefit, but he's also technically very sound. These guys are all strong, but it's not about how much you can lift or sprint.